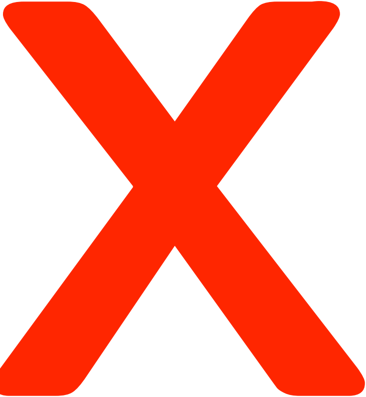
Earthy = Marsy

Earthy = Venusy

But, for reasons we have already discussed — namely, the fact that identity is transitive — these three claims do not sit well together. So it appears that the psychological theory implies a contradiction.

Marsy ≠ Venusy



Basically the same point could be made about the version of the story on which, after the transmission to Mars, the individual who steps into the teletransporter on Earth steps back out. To tell that version of the story, we'd just need to introduce two names — Earthy-1 and Earthy-2 — for the individual on earth pre-teletransportation, and the individual who exists after the teletransportation.

It is easy enough to turn this into an argument against the psychological theory of survival.

1. If the psychological theory of survival is true, then Earthy = Marsy.
2. If the psychological theory of survival is true, then Earthy = Venusy.
3. If the psychological theory of survival is true, then Marsy = Venusy. (1,2)
4. Marsy ≠Venusy.

C. The psychological theory of survival is false. (3,4)

We now have three "pure" views of personal identity on the table, along with the various combinations of those views.

The teletransportation argument

Why are these cases puzzling from the point of view of theories of survival?

Our topic today is a cluster of puzzles about identity and survival. These puzzles put pressure, in different ways, on some of true assumptions about survival we have been making so far.

One good way to test out your preferred view of survival is to think about what your view implies with respect to these three puzzles.

Now think about a case in which a split-brain patient has a red stimulus presented to the right half of their visual field, and a blue stimulus presented to the left half of their visual field. If you ask the subject what color they see, they will say “Red”, since this was the color presented to the part of the eye which feeds input to the left hemisphere of the brain, which controls speech. If you ask the person to pick out with their left hand an object of the same color as the one they saw, they will pick out a blue object.

But this implies that, at least while they are being given stimuli of this kind, the bodies of split brain patients are inhabited by two people.

But if this is right, one of the following must be true:

(1) While the split brain patients are in experiments of this sort, there are two persons inhabiting their body; but, at other times, there is just one person inhabiting their body.

(2) Split brain patients always have two persons inhabiting their body, but non-split brain subjects do not.

(3) All of us, split-brain and non-split-brain subjects alike, have two (or more) persons inhabiting their body.

One kind of response to these cases is to call into question an assumption that we found plausible when introducing the survival question: the assumption that there must always be a determinate fact of the matter about whether X and Y are the same person.

It is at least somewhat plausible that the corresponding assumption is false about some complex entities. Consider, for example, sports teams. We might ask whether the Notre Dame football team in week 1 of next year's season is **really the same team as** the team in week 5.

In one sense, they are clearly the same team. But we can also suppose that they have had some injuries and transfers, so that the players are not the same. In that sense, they are different teams. Here there is some temptation to think that the question, ‘Is this numerically one team?’ has no determinate answer.

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